ELSEVIER JOURNALS · GENERATIVE AI POLICIES

Generative AI Policies for Journals

What Elsevier expects from authors, reviewers and editors: use, disclosure, images and confidentiality

Declare | Verify | Keep it private

Summarised from the Elsevier policy page (updated June 2026) · accessed 29 October 2026

ELSEVIER'S POSITION

Three principles behind the policy

1
Human oversight
AI must never substitute for human critical thinking, expertise and evaluation. You stay accountable.

2
Transparency
Declare AI use beyond basic checks. Describe AI used in the research itself in the Methods.

3
Confidentiality
Never upload a manuscript under review to an AI tool. Use only private AI tools, and only in a supportive role.

> Generative AI here means tools that produce text, images, audio or synthetic data, such as ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, Claude and DALL·E. Use varies by journal, so contact the journal with questions.

AUTHORS · PERMITTED USE

What AI may support, and what it may not replace

May support

- Synthesising literature and getting an overview of a field
- Identifying research gaps and generating ideas
- Organising content
- Improving language and readability
- Checking completeness against guidelines

Must never replace

- Your critical thinking, expertise and evaluation
- Your own intellectual contribution to each section
- Real data, results and references

Use must involve human oversight and control. Authors remain responsible and accountable for the work.

AUTHORS · ACCOUNTABILITY

Verify the output, vet the tool

Your duties

- Check accuracy, completeness and impartiality, including sources. AI references can be incorrect or fabricated.
- Edit and adapt AI-assisted material so it reflects your own analysis and ideas.
- Make use of tools and sources clear to readers.
- Check outputs for factual errors and bias.

Check the tool's terms

- Inputs, including unpublished manuscripts, stay private and confidential.
- The tool gets only the right to provide the service, not other rights such as training rights.
- Outputs are not restricted in a way that could limit later publication.
- Take particular care with personally identifiable data.

AUTHORS · DISCLOSURE

When to declare, and where

Situation	Declare?	Where
Basic grammar, spelling and punctuation checks	No	Not needed
AI inside assistive technology for accessibility	No	Not needed
Substantive changes to sentence structure or text organisation	Yes	AI declaration statement
AI used in the research process, not manuscript preparation	Yes	Methods section
AI used to make explanatory images	Yes	Image caption and AI declaration statement

> The AI declaration statement is a separate statement submitted with the manuscript. It appears in the published article.

AUTHORS · DECLARATION TEMPLATE

The recommended statement

Section title

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process

Statement

During the preparation of this work, the author(s) used [NAME OF TOOL / SERVICE] in order to [REASON]. After using this tool, the author(s) reviewed and edited the content as needed and take(s) full responsibility for the content of the published article.

Record three things

- The name of the tool
- The purpose of use
- The extent of your oversight

AUTHORS · AUTHORSHIP AND LIMITS

Authorship stays human

What authorship requires

- AI tools cannot be listed as authors or co-authors, or cited as authors.
- Authors approve the final version and agree to submission.
- Each author helps resolve questions about accuracy or integrity.
- The work is original, unpublished and infringes no third-party rights.

Not permitted (examples)

- Generating sections without genuine intellectual contribution from you
- Fabricating or altering research data, results or references
- Generating or altering images that represent research results

Read Elsevier's Ethics in Publishing policy before you submit.

FIGURES, IMAGES AND ARTWORK

Three kinds of image, three sets of rules

Allowed with disclosure

1. Explanatory images

Flow charts, decision trees, timelines, conceptual schematics, workflow diagrams. State the tool, version and use in the caption and the AI declaration.

Tightly limited

2. Research and data images

Data visualisations only if derived directly from your data by reproducible methods. Primary research images must not be created or altered by AI.

Not with general tools

3. Graphical abstracts, cover art

General-purpose generative image tools must not make graphical abstracts. Cover art needs prior permission.

IMAGES · RESEARCH AND DATA

Data visualisations and primary images

Data visualisations

Plots, charts, graphs, heatmaps. AI may be used only if the output is directly derived from your data by reproducible methods reported in Methods.

Name the tool, version and developer. Never fabricate or alter data.

Primary research images

Microscopy, histology, western blots, scans, patient images. AI must not create or alter images representing primary data.

Brightness, contrast and colour changes use established image-processing software.

Research methods exception

AI may be part of formal research design, such as AI-assisted imaging for data collection or predictive modelling.

Describe it reproducibly in Methods with tool, version and developer.

> For plots of numerical results, keep the script and the result files that generate each figure.

IMAGES · ABSTRACTS, COVER ART, YOUR DUTIES

Graphical abstracts and image responsibilities

Graphical abstracts

General-purpose generative AI image tools must not be used. Dedicated scientific illustration tools, with defined licensing terms, are encouraged.

Journal cover art

May be permitted in some cases, with prior permission from the editor and publisher, proof of third-party permissions, and attribution.

Your responsibilities

- Ensure accuracy and originality.
- Attribute and get permission for any existing artwork used as a basis.
- Do not generate images that copy or refer to copyrighted images, real people, or identifiable products or brands.
- Do not generate a likeness of an individual's voice.

REVIEWERS · CONFIDENTIALITY AND PERMITTED USE

What reviewers may and may not do

Status	Use of AI	Condition
Not permitted	Upload a submitted manuscript, or any part of it, into any AI tool	No exception stated
Permitted	Improve the language and structure of your report	Private AI tool only
Permitted	Assist a background literature search	Private AI tool only

> AI cannot replace your critical, independent evaluation, and may produce incorrect, incomplete or biased conclusions. You remain fully accountable for your report.

REVIEWERS · PRIVATE TOOLS AND DISCLOSURE

What counts as a private AI tool

Definition

It does not retain, reuse, share or learn from submitted content. Input is kept no longer than the service needs, does not train the model, and is not shared with third parties.

Checks before use

Read the privacy policy and terms on retention and training. Prefer paid, enterprise or locally hosted models over free tools, and verify even then.

Disclosing in your report

State the tool and the purpose. Basic spelling and grammar checks need no disclosure.

> During the preparation of this report, I used [NAME OF TOOL / SERVICE] in order to [REASON]. I reviewed and edited the content and take full responsibility for it.

EDITORS

Editorial judgement stays with the editor

Inside Elsevier's systems

Editors have private AI tools for identifying reviewers, matching submission scope and detecting duplicate submissions.

Outside those systems

Only private AI tools, in a supportive role: improving the language or structure of decision letters, or a background literature search.

Never

Upload a submitted manuscript, or any part of it, into an AI tool outside Elsevier's editorial systems.

> Editors remain responsible for the assessment, the final decision and communicating it. The policy sets no specific rules for editors' use of AI detection tools.

HOW ELSEVIER USES AI

AI in Elsevier's own processes

For editors

Tools that help identify reviewers, match submission scope and detect duplicate submissions.

For authors

Journal Finder suggests suitable journals. The Article Transfer Service may suggest alternatives.

For internal teams

Technical checks against guidelines, research integrity checks, and post-acceptance support such as proofs and copy editing.

> Human oversight stays central to decisions. Tools follow the RELX Responsible AI Principles, are evaluated for bias, and must meet data privacy and security requirements.

COMPARISON

Elsevier, Wiley and Springer Nature

Topic	Elsevier	Wiley	Springer Nature
Language edits	Basic grammar, spelling, punctuation: no declaration	Grammar, spelling, word choice: no disclosure	Green: describe the use
Where to declare	Separate AI declaration statement, printed in the article	Acknowledgments, Methods or captions	Introduction or Acknowledgements; Methods; AI Declaration for visuals
Images	No general-purpose AI for graphical abstracts or primary images	No AI-edited photographs; charts allowed	Verifiable-input visuals allowed with disclosure
Reviewer use	Private tools only: language, structure, background search	Clarity, tone, translation; no manuscript content	Green, amber, red by risk
Detectors	No editor rules stated	Not addressed	Extreme caution

PRACTICE · OPTIMISATION CASES

What would you do?

A

An LLM fixes spelling, grammar and punctuation in your introduction.

B

An LLM reorganises two sections of your paper and rewrites their sentences.

C

An LLM writes the code for the solver and benchmark scripts behind your experiments.

D

An AI tool makes your performance profile from the results file with a script you keep.

E

You make the graphical abstract with a general-purpose image generator.

F

Reviewer: you paste the paper's abstract into a paid chatbot to get a summary.

PRACTICE · SUGGESTED ANSWERS

What the Elsevier page implies

Case	Answer	Why
A	No declaration	Basic grammar, spelling and punctuation checks do not need declaration.
B	Declare	Substantive changes to sentence structure or organisation go in the AI declaration statement.
C	Describe in Methods	AI used in the research process belongs in Methods. Name the tool and version, and say how you tested the code.
D	Allowed, in Methods	Output must derive directly from your data by a reproducible method. Report tool, version and developer.
E	Not permitted	General-purpose generative image tools must not make graphical abstracts. Use a dedicated scientific illustration tool.
F	Not permitted	No part of a submitted manuscript may go into any AI tool, paid or not.

PRACTICE · CHECKLISTS

Before you submit, review or decide

Authors

- ✓ **Terms.** No training rights; outputs not restricted.
- ✓ **Verified.** Every reference and claim checked against sources.
- ✓ **Declaration.** Separate statement with tool, purpose and oversight.
- ✓ **Methods.** AI used in the research is described reproducibly.
- ✓ **Images.** Data plots derive from data; no general tools for graphical abstracts.

Reviewers and editors

- ✓ **No uploads.** No part of the manuscript went into an AI tool.
- ✓ **Private tool.** It does not retain, reuse, share or learn from input.
- ✓ **Supportive role.** Language, structure or background search only.
- ✓ **Disclosure.** Reviewers state tool and purpose in the report.
- ✓ **My judgement.** The assessment or decision is my own.

SOURCES AND SCOPE

Where this guide comes from

Elsevier: Generative AI policies for journals
elsevier.com/.../generative-ai-policies-for-journals

Comparison columns
The Wiley and Springer Nature pages summarised in the earlier decks on this site.

Scope and caveats

> The page (updated June 2026) was read on 29 October 2026 through a summarising tool, so wording is paraphrased apart from short quotes.

> Most FAQ answers (code, translation, reference checks, where to disclose) had no text in the version read. The slides use the main sections.

> The books policy and Ethics in Publishing were not reviewed. The comparison, scenarios and checklists are written for this deck.